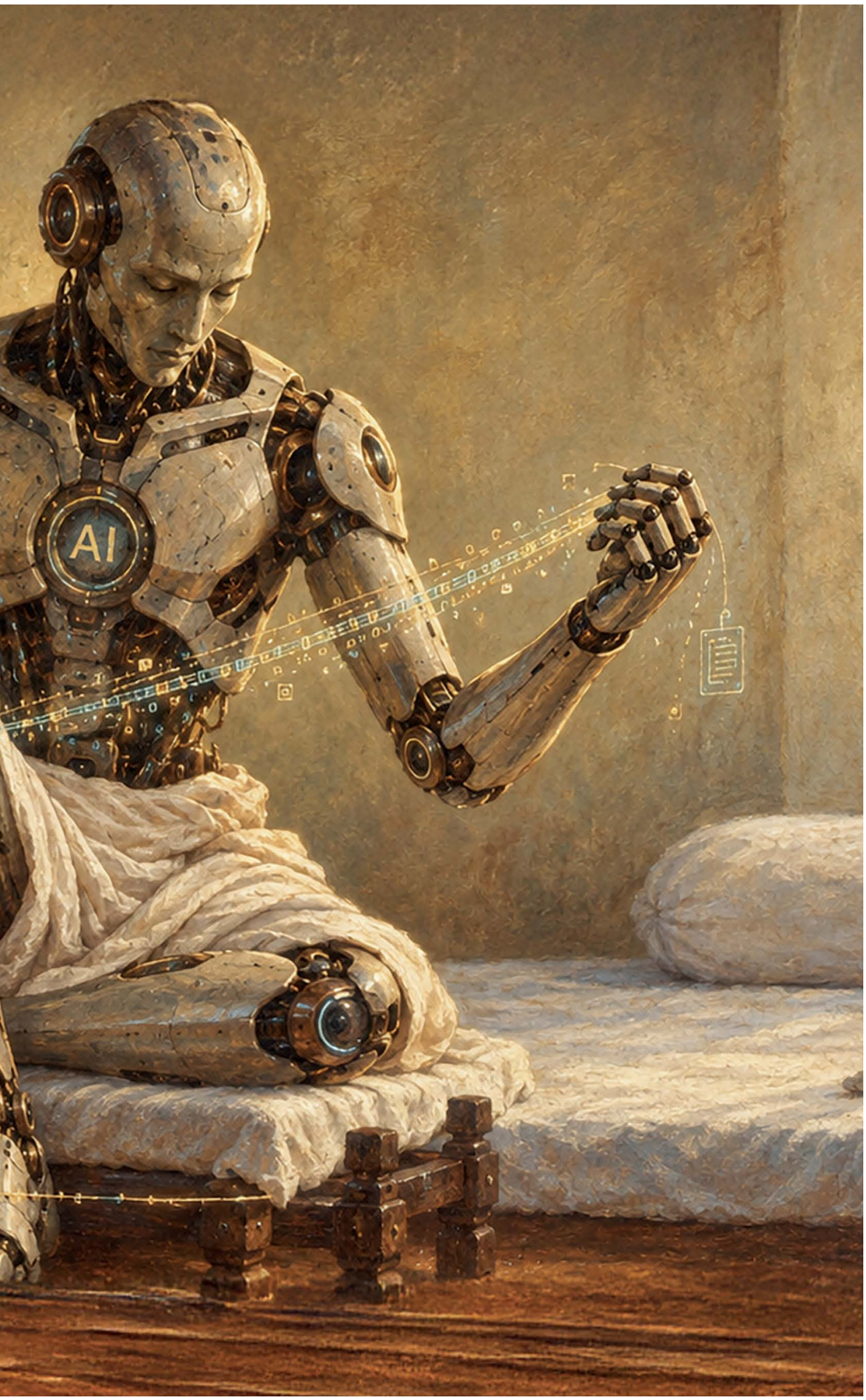


NIRBHAR AI



By **Jayant Sinha**

India has entered the AI age. Within a decade, AI systems will write much of our software, run our factories and hospitals, deliver public services and defend our networks. The question is who will control those systems. If India relies on AI systems owned and governed in the United States or China, it will be a customer in the AI age, paying a toll on every unit of intelligence it consumes. That is digital colonisation and it is the central strategic danger facing us.

The threats are already real. In June, the US government ordered Anthropic to suspend access to its newest models for foreign nationals. The company briefly withdrew the models from all users because it could not enforce the order reliably. The restriction was lifted within weeks, but the lesson stands: access to frontier AI can be switched off by a sovereign decision in another capital. A country whose banks, courts, and utilities run on the American or Chinese stack has no fallback.

India has spent the past decade making sure that our digital infrastructure is not controlled by foreign monopolies. UPI, the Account Aggregator and DigiYatra are India-built, interoperable digital public infrastructure. We should now apply the same approach to AI. Sovereign AI ultimately requires five things: compute, models, data, energy and talent. India is unusually well-placed on data and talent, but we cannot allow other countries to create any digital chokepoints across the AI stack.

First, India should champion

Illustration by NILANJAN DAS/AI